was non-existent" at independence and was gradually "extended to the Subansiri Division in 1949, to the Abor and Mishmi Hills districts in 1949–50, and to Tawang in February 1951."[20] As for communications, Ladakh did not have a single road, and even Leh was not connected by road to Srinagar. The situation was worse in NEFA; it had no roads, even in the foothills. The absence of both administration and communications meant that these areas were undeveloped. There were only three primary schools in NEFA, while the only education available in Ladakh was in monasteries. Whereas Leh had some medical facilities, in NEFA, these existed only in Pasighat in the foothills.[21] In effect, the Indian state was practically non-existent in these regions. Therefore, the first task was to extend administration to these areas, establish communications with and within these regions, and initiate developmental activities. As Steven Hoffmann has pointed out, the concept of internal balancing can logically be expanded to cover "administrative and military steps to consolidate a frontier zone."[22]

The initial steps to extend administration and establish communications received a fillip after the North and North-East Border Defence Committee, headed by the then–Deputy Defence Minister, Major General Himmatsinhji Jadeja, submitted its report in two parts, the first in April and the second in September 1951. Constituted in February 1951 in the wake of China's invasion of Tibet and the ensuing policy debate between Nehru and Patel, the committee recommended a slew of measures, including "the reorganization and expansion of the Assam Rifles, the extension of administration in the NEFA area, development of intelligence network along the border, development of the border areas, development of civil armed police, development of communications and check-posts."[23] Part one of the report covered the border regions extending from